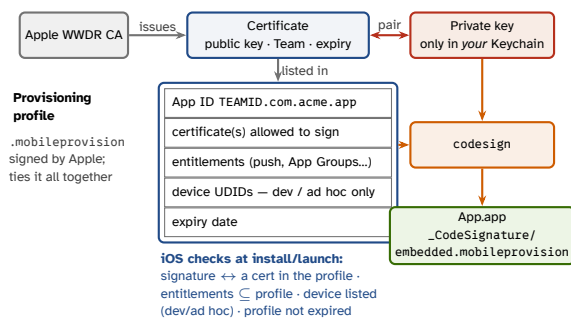
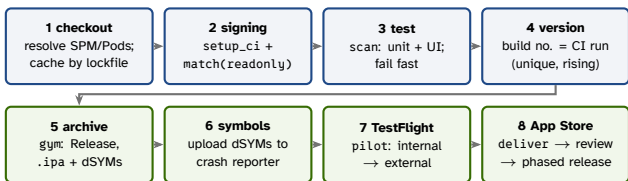


In one line: A build runs on a device only if it is **signed with a certificate's private key** and carries a **provisioning profile** that lists that certificate, the **App ID**, the **entitlements** and (dev/ad hoc) the **device**. CI breaks because the runner has none of that — **fastlane match + an App Store Connect API key** make signing and upload reproducible and non-interactive.



CI pipeline (fastlane action)



TestFlight: internal ≤ 100 team users, no review · external ≤ 10,000; the first build added to a group goes to App Review, later ones may not need a full one · 90 days per build.
Phased release: 1 · 2 · 5 · 10 · 20 · 50 · 100 % over 7 days, automatic updates only; pause ≤ 30 days in total, not a rollback. **Secrets**: MATCH_PASSWORD, ASC key · p8 + Key ID + Issuer ID in the CI secret store; ephemeral keychain per job.

Profile types

Profile	Certificate	Devices	Use
Development	Apple Development	listed UDIDs	run + debug (get-task-allow)
Ad Hoc	Apple Distribution	listed UDIDs	QA outside TestFlight
App Store	Apple Distribution	none	TestFlight + App Store
Enterprise	In-House (Enterprise Program)	none	internal staff only, never public

Example — Fastfile (Ruby)

```
lane :beta do
  setup_ci # temp unlocked keychain on CI
  key = app_store_connect_api_key(key_id: ENV["ASC_KEY_ID"],
    issuer_id: ENV["ASC_ISSUER_ID"], key_content: ENV["ASC_P8"])
  match(type: "appstore", readonly: true, api_key: key)
  run_tests(scheme: "App") # scan
  increment_build_number(build_number: ENV["CI_RUN_NUMBER"])
  build_app(scheme: "App", export_method: "app-store") # gym
  upload_symbols_to_crashlytics # dSYMs
  upload_to_testflight(api_key: key) # pilot
end
```

How it works

- The **profile** picks the channel, not the certificate: one Distribution cert signs both Ad Hoc and App Store builds.
- Capability flow**: enable it on the App ID → regenerate the profile → add it to .entitlements. All three must agree.
- Automatic signing** = Xcode creates certs/profiles with a logged-in Apple ID: fine locally, flaky on CI. **Manual** = named profile + identity: reproducible.
- match** stores certs + profiles in git, S3, Google Cloud or GitLab Secure Files and installs the same ones on every laptop and runner — *encrypted* with MATCH_PASSWORD in git and S3 only; the others rely on bucket access. `readonly: true` on CI so it never creates or revokes. iOS types: development, adhoc, appstore, enterprise.
- ASC API key** = Issuer ID + Key ID + .p8 (downloadable once); signs an ES256 JWT that lives ≤ 20 min, reused until it expires. No password, no 2FA, role-scoped, revocable; a *team* key — individual keys cannot reach the provisioning endpoints. Apple ID auth needs 2FA sessions that expire (*unverified*).
- Version vs build**: `CFBundleShortVersionString` (2.4.0, user-facing) vs `CFBundleVersion` (1387) — unique and increasing per upload of a version (*unverified*).
- Build once, promote the artifact**: the .ipa you tested in TestFlight is the one you submit; never rebuild for release.
- Caching**: key SPM/Pods caches on `Package.resolved` / `Podfile.lock` + Xcode version — keyed on branch only, they go stale.

Remember

“Key + Cert + Profile = permission to run; match shares them, the API key uploads them.”

Traps

- ! **“Works on my Mac, fails on CI”**: your Keychain has the private key; the runner doesn’t. A .cer without its private key cannot sign.
- ! `errSecInternalComponent` / “User interaction is not allowed” = locked keychain or key ACL (*unverified*) → `setup_ci` or `security set-key-partition-list`.
- ! Automatic signing on CI keeps minting distribution certs until the account limit (*unverified*).
- ! Capability works in Debug, missing in the App Store build → the distribution profile was not regenerated after enabling it on the App ID.
- ! Duplicate `CFBundleVersion` → App Store Connect rejects the upload (*unverified*).
- ! Never commit .p12/.p8 in plain text or echo a secret in a job — CI logs are kept.
- ! Phased release can be paused, not rolled back; a bad build needs a new build.